

KEEP THIS ONE; IT LIVES NEXT TO YOUR SEND BUTTON

AI for Communication: Parent Messages and Tone

THE STANCE

AI drafts the message; you make it yours. Families hear you, not the tool.

And hard news is never delivered by a draft: you call.

Why one sentence matters

In a field experiment set in a summer program for students retaking a course they had failed, one individualized sentence home per week cut the share of students failing to earn the credit from 15.8% to 9.3%, a 41% reduction, with improvement-focused messages working best (Kraft & Rogers, 2015). Personal-at-scale used to cost hours. It doesn't anymore.

Prompt 1 · The weekly message

"You are a warm, organized teacher. Draft this week's family [newsletter / update] for my class. Context: [what happened, what's coming, what families must do and by when]. Format: under 150 words, skimmable on a phone, action items as a short bulleted list, one positive line about the class's week."

Prompt 2 · The difficult email (tone repair)

"Draft a calm, professional reply to a frustrated parent who [general situation, no names]. Acknowledge the frustration, explain that specifics belong in a conversation, offer two meeting times, keep it under 120 words, firm and warm."

The 24-hour rule: anything written angry waits a day unless safety can't wait. The vent draft gets deleted, not sent.

Prompt 3 · The positive-note batch

"Write 12 one-sentence positive note starters a teacher could send to families, warm and improvement-focused, grouped by situation (persistence, kindness, turnaround, leadership, progress). No student names; I'll personalize each one myself."

Pick three a week. Personalize each in your own email, where names belong. That's the research-backed habit, at five minutes a week. First run: Send 2 on your First 48 Hours sheet.

Prompt 4 · The hard sentence

"Rewrite this sentence for a message to families so it is warm, plain, and guilt-free, and ends with exactly what to do and by when: [paste your sentence, no names]."

Almost every real message carries one item you'd rather not write: the fee reminder, the missing slips, the gentle nag. Repair that sentence before it repairs your relationships downward.

The tone-repair kit

Tool	Use it when
"Warmer." "Shorter." "Plainer."	Ninety percent of drafts need exactly one of these
The read-aloud test	Your ear knows your voice; if it doesn't sound like you, retype it the way you'd say it
Lead with the action	Action items go on top, with dates; families skim on phones, and the buried request is the missed request
The tired-parent test	Before it sends, read it as a tired parent on a phone at 9 p.m.; that's who's reading it
The 24-hour rule	Anything written angry; tomorrow-you sends better email

The red line: no public AI translation of family messages; you cannot review what you cannot read. Official documents travel your district's translation channels. Plain language is how your message reaches every family, including multilingual ones.

The human-only list (never a draft)

Safety concerns · serious discipline · a family's grief · special-education decisions. For these, call first, in your own voice. Written follow-up comes later, written by you.

The permanent rules ride along: the situation, never the child, goes into the tool. And nothing AI-drafted reaches a family unread and unpersonalized.

Three families getting a positive note this week (initials only, kept by you)

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